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At around noon Eastern on Tuesday, FX's *The Bear* surprised-dropped a stand-alone episode called "Gary." The hour-long two-hander, set before the events of the show's first episode, arrived with so little advance notice that Ebon Moss-Bachrach, who [announced the event on his Instagram feed](#), had to tell his followers to search for it by name, presumably since it hadn't yet been added to the show's homepage on Hulu.

"Gary" was co-written by Moss-Bachrach and Jon Bernthal, who play *The Bear*'s Richie and Mikey, and the timing of the drop suggested it was meant to get a boost from the Tony nominations, since the two are also currently starring in *Dog Day Afternoon* on Broadway. (It also gets the episode in under the wire for Emmys consideration.) The play, a rudderless adaptation of the classic 1975 movie, didn't make out as hoped, Tony-wise, but it's a reminder that the duo, who also acted opposite each other in the Netflix series *The Punisher*, make for a great double act, especially when they're free to just bounce off one another with no need to advance any kind of a plot.

The episode, directed by *The Bear* showrunner Chris Storer, starts with Richie (Moss-Bachrach) leaving his very pregnant wife, Tiff (Gillian Jacobs), to run what's meant to be a brief errand with Mikey (Bernthal), ferrying a cardboard box with undisclosed contents to Gary, Indiana, about an hour's drive away. The setup suggests some kind of *Pulp Fiction*-type payoff, as does the handgun Richie jams into the car's glove box before they pull away from the curb. There's even a ticking clock, since the superstitious Tiff tells Richie he needs to be home by 5:15, as she's convinced she's going to have their first child at the same time her mother gave birth to her.

All that urgency evaporates the moment the two friends get to Gary—or, really, as soon as Richie pops in the mix CD he's burned especially for the drive. The episode opens with the frenzied pounding of Yes' "Heart of the Sunrise," but as soon as Richie's choosing the tunes, it's all mellow, loping reggae. (Evidently, he hasn't yet [discovered Taylor Swift](#).) No sooner have Richie and Mikey arrived in Gary than they're told they've got several hours to kill until whoever it is picks up whatever's in that box, and they've got nothing to do but kill time.

Fortunately, killing time is what *The Bear* does best. The show's recent seasons have gotten so invested in protagonist Carmy's inner torment and the question of whether he'll be able to convert a [beloved neighborhood sandwich joint](#) into a Michelin-starred gem that it's lost sight of how good it can be when there's nothing more at stake than finding out more about the people around him. Although "Gary" also serves as a teaser for the show's upcoming final season—slated to come out in June—the suggestive but otherwise unexplained shots of a burning field dotted throughout the episode suggest it was originally meant to be stationed somewhere in the middle, a digression along the lines of past standouts like Season 3's Tina-focused "Napkins" and Season 4's Sydney-centric "[Worms](#)." But even if you can't remember exactly where the story left off, the episode works perfectly well on its own, because Moss-Bachrach and Bernthal's performances are so rich and complete you don't even need to remember that Mikey, Carmy's older brother and the original owner of the sandwich shop, is a few months away from dying by suicide to understand what's going on in their heads.

"Gary" starts out like any other guys' trip: The two stop off for fast food at Gary's real-life Koney King, trash-talk some men half their age on a basketball court, even get a look at the house where Michael Jackson grew up. But once they realize there are more hours to fill than aimless goofing-

around can account for, they start getting high, and the unhappiness both men are keeping at bay crashes to the surface.

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Richie suggests they detour to the nearest bar, and while Mikey stays in the car for a bit, he's eventually lured in by Sherri (Marin Ireland), a single redhead Richie knows his best friend will be powerless to resist. While Richie regales a table full of strangers with drunken stories, Mikey and Sherri form an instant bond, the kind that might quickly turn to love if Mikey were capable of receiving it. They retire to a bathroom stall, where he smokes more weed and does more coke, and Mikey starts to let down his guard, which he desperately needs to do. But he's got so much bottled up that he can't control it, and his hurt converts to anger like water hitting a hot pan.

Ireland is a prolific character actress as well as a constant presence on the New York stage, and she packs a lot into Sherri's few minutes onscreen. In practical terms, her job is to serve as Bernthal's sounding board, to convey enough compassion that even a hard-boiled guy like Mikey will feel safe letting down his guard. But she brings so much more to the part, suggesting a complex past we'll probably never get to explore, and a whole life that the doomed Mikey might have gotten to lead. The scenes between her and Bernthal are some of *The Bear's* most intense and also its quietest, without the shrieking faux drama of the overwrought holiday episode "Fishes." And it helps that "Gary" truly stands alone, with no sense that we're itching to get back to what's going on in with Carmy in the kitchen. As wrenching as the episode can be, it's also unexpectedly leisurely, because the only thing it's concerned with is right there in front of us. It takes its time, and every second counts.

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